

Figure 1.3 *Congregational Mosque, Isfahan,* c. *1090* CE, *interior: south dome chamber.* © *Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*



Figure 1.4 Minar *known as Chihil Dukhtaran,* c. *1100* CE, *Jubara quarter, Isfahan.* © *Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

twelfth-century structures of the Iranian Plateau constituted the cosmopolitan expressions of what has been termed "Saljuq-patronized" architectural culture.[40] Building upon "what had gone before," the array of public/"civic" and palatial buildings subscribing to it were individual and varied, sharing general but uniquely expressed characteristics. Nevertheless, the combination of salient features circumscribing this architectural culture is identifiable: baked brick as the primary building material, with an increasing use of blue-glazed tiles for decoration; lofty hemispherical domes; squat, pointed arches; emphatic portals (*pishtaq*); extensive and stylistically varied, usually painted, architectural epigraphy; brick and stucco decorations of repeated geometric and floral-arabesque iconographies (deriving from Abbasid-period stucco practices), also painted; and, where present, cylindrical and soaring, "pencil-thin" *minar*s.[41] For our purposes,